BOOKS ▶

CAT ON THE ROOF OF THE WORLD

IN A COMPELLING ACCOUNT OF TWO DECADES SPENT STUDYING THE ELUSIVE SNOW LEOPARD, KULBHUSHANSINGH SURYAWANSHI EXPLORES THE COMPLEXITIES OF CONSERVATION



THE GHOST OF THE MOUNTAINS
Unravelling the Secrets of the Snow Leopard
By Kulbhushansingh Suryawanshi
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In Peter Matthiessen's *The Snow Leopard*, the author famously never sees one in his Himalayan quest. Scientist and conservationist Kulbhushansingh 'Kullu' Suryawanshi's first encounter is another potent absence: a pugmark impressed over his own shoeprint. The animal was around, watching.

This was the prelude to many sightings during his two decades studying the snow leopard in Spiti, Himachal Pradesh, Ladakh and Central Asia—each enthralling and offering insight into this elusive big cat: the mother who greets her cubs with love even as they unwittingly sabotage her hard-earned hunt; a pair snuggling, playing, frolicking, courting and mating; and siblings working in sync to corner ibex.

Kullu's first sighting carries special meaning. From the rooftop of a friend's home, he watched through a spotting scope as the cat glided through powdery snow—a sight celebrated by the entire village. This was gratifying: almost none of the villagers had ever seen a snow leopard, though they lived with it. However, snow leopards prey on livestock, and retaliation can be swift. One herder had lost 30 goats in one night and the offending cat had been "dispatched and thrown in the river". But there is empathy: "snow leopards need to eat too"; the occasional loss was acceptable, but compensation was essential.

THE ACCOUNT OF THE SNOW LEOPARD'S **DOWNLISTING TO 'VULNERABLE'** RAISES DIFFICULT QUESTIONS

At the outset, Kullu had naively believed that he was entering a "place of unadulterated nature", leaving human problems behind. But the lives of snow leopards are enmeshed with those of the pastoralists whose landscapes they share. Kullu devotes time devising ways for safer co-existence: strengthening livestock corrals, improving compensation and listening to those who live alongside the cat. The social insights are revelatory: for example, that women harbour greater antipathy towards the cat, possibly as they bear greater emotional and social cost.

The book is alert to the politics of conservation. Kullu's impassioned account of the snow leopard's controversial 2017 downlisting from 'endangered' to 'vulnerable' raises difficult questions. The book confronts other threats: the climate crisis and, ironically, some of humanity's "solutions" to it, as vast solar parks consume huge tracts of critical snow leopard habitat.

Kullu's writing is vivid, fresh, his voice is passionate but shorn of romance—highlighting the grind such work demands. His words makes the ghost visible, while—thankfully—retaining its mystique, portraying the snow leopard in all its fragile beauty, vulnerability and its intimate entanglement with human lives. ■

—Prerna Singh Bindra